

Job Hunt — Michael Kushman

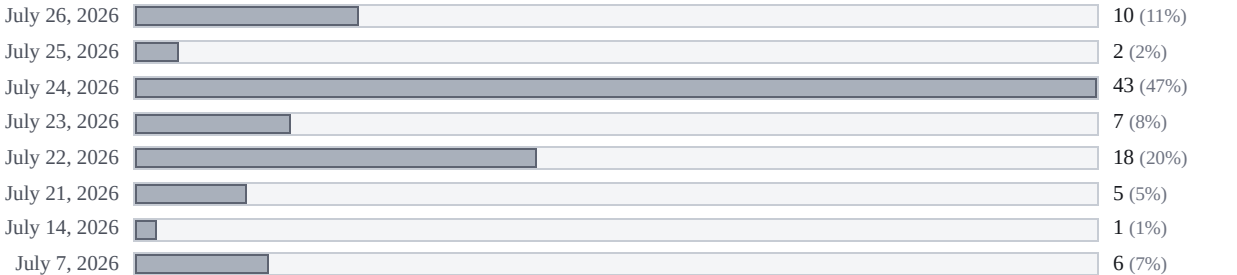
Verified application ledger · Gmail and Drive reconciled · simple tracker linked from the website

Updated July 27, 2026 — 92 verified applications · Rillet and AIRE passed · first human reply of the campaign (Sage Recruiting)

92	37	1	1	3	5	4
APPLICATIONS IN	ATS CONFIRMATIONS	HUMAN REPLIES	LIVE CONVERSATIONS	REJECTIONS	IN PIPELINE	BACKLOG

How many went out, by day

92 verified applications across 8 active days. Bars are to scale against the busiest day.



Where all 92 stand today

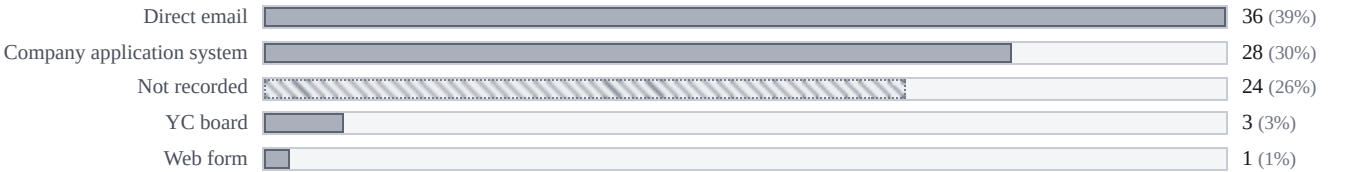
Every status carries its own label, count and fill pattern — the chart is readable in black and white, and colour is never the only cue.



	Rejected	They said no.	3 (3%)
	Submitted, no reply	Sent. Nobody has acknowledged it.	53 (58%)
	Confirmed received	Their system said it arrived.	35 (38%)
	A human engaged	Someone actually replied and talked.	1 (1%)
	Never arrived	Bounced or withdrawn before it landed.	none
	Cold outreach	No posted job; introduced myself anyway.	none

How the applications were sent

Read from the notes column. “Not recorded” means the note does not say how it went out — it is shown, not hidden, because it is a real share of the ledger.



Why the confirmation numbers differ

The scoreboard says 37 ATS confirmations, but only 35 rows below currently read “Confirmed received.” Both are correct. 37 is *cumulative* — every confirmation ever received. The ledger shows *current state*, and 2 of those confirmations (Rillet and Tsenta) were superseded by a later outcome, so those rows now show that outcome instead. Nothing was lost and nothing was double-counted.

What counts: Submitted applications and delivered live-role emails count; drafts, bounces, opened forms, research, speculative outreach, and duplicate resends do not.
Standing rules: Deduplicate by company, role, and earliest submission date. Resends update the existing row; distinct roles at the same company remain separate.

The full ledger

All 92 verified applications, newest day first. Each entry carries its status in words, plus the channel it went out through.

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
JULY 26, 2026 — 10 VERIFIED					
Aurorin CAD	Founding Engineer	\$120–160K + 3–4%	San Francisco, CA	Confirmed received	7/26
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Applied via Polymer · successful submission confirmed · ycombinator.com					
Awell Health	Product Engineer	\$100–180K + eq	Remote · US-time-zone hours	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@awellhealth.com · corrected resend added résumé · counted once · awellhealth.com					
Eagle	Design Engineer	\$150–300K + eq	NYC · on-site	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to tom@eagleeng.com · résumé attached · jobs.ashbyhq.com					
Guac	Fullstack Engineer	\$150–250K + 0.5–1%	NYC · on-site 5d/wk	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to jack@guac-ai.com · résumé attached · ycombinator.com					
InstaLILY AI	Design Engineer	\$100–120K + eq	NYC	Confirmed received	7/26
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse confirmation received · moved from backlog · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
Outmarket	Front-End AI Engineer	Competitive + eq	Remote · US or India	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@outmarket.ai · delivered; Gmail metadata shows no attachment · outmarket.ai					
PrairieLearn	Full-Stack Software Engineer	\$100–180K + eq	Remote US	Confirmed received	7/26
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby confirmation received · jobs.ashbyhq.com					
Profound	Design Engineer	\$120–250K	NYC / Buenos Aires · on-site	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to dylan@tryprofound.com · résumé attached · tryprofound.com					
ProxyBase	Full-Stack Developer	\$100–160K + eq	Remote global	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to jobs@proxybase.xyz · role-specific pitch delivered; Gmail metadata shows no attachment · proxybase.xyz					
Sylience (Chord)	Founding Engineer	\$100–150K + 1–5%	Remote · US time zones	Submitted, no reply	7/26
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@sylience.com · delivered; Gmail metadata shows no attachment · sylience.com					
JULY 25, 2026 — 2 VERIFIED					
Counterpart	Product Engineer	\$110K+ est.	Remote US	Confirmed received	7/25
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse confirmation received · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
elly	Role not stated (Greenhouse confirmation)	—	—	Confirmed received	7/25
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse receipt proves submission but omits title · role deliberately not inferred · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
JULY 24, 2026 — 43 VERIFIED					
AIRE	Founding Engineer	\$100–250K + eq	Remote US/Canada · NYC preferred	Rejected	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Passed 7/27 — Ashley at Sage Recruiting replied by hand: not a fit for the current role, keeping him on their hotlist for future openings · FIRST human reply of the campaign · cold email to recruitment@aire.xyz 7/24 · aire.xyz					
Arterial	Junior Full-Stack Engineer	—	Remote US	Confirmed received	7/24
NOT RECORDED Application receipt confirmed materials and role · arterial.us					

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Atria Health	Staff Software Engineer, Agentic AI	\$230–290K	NYC hybrid · Tue–Thu	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to talent@atria.org delivered · auto-reply directed candidates to site · apply.workable.com				
Avery	Software Engineer	—	On-site / Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to info@averyiq.com · delivered; no bounce · averyiq.com				
Catalyst Wayfare	AI Engineer / Agent Builder	—	Remote US · Eastern overlap	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to talent@cwai.co · delivered; no bounce · catalystwayfare.ai				
Colonist	Product Engineer	—	—	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	colonist.io · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com				
Cora AI	Founding Full Stack / Applied AI Engineer	\$190–250K + eq	Remote US / SF	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers@cora.ai · moved from backlog · cora.ai				
DearHiringManager.io	Full-Stack Developer	\$120–160K	Remote · US/EU time zones	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to lars@dearhiringmanager.io · delivered; no bounce · dearhiringmanager.io				
Deployment.io	Forward Deployed Engineer	Competitive + eq	Remote US or India	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to jobs@deployment.io 7/24 · resent 7/26 · counted once · deployment.io				
DwellSafe	Full-Stack Engineer	—	—	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers@dwellsafe.ai · delivered; no bounce · dwellsafe.ai				
Emergences	AI / Systems Engineer	\$120–150K + eq	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to jack@emergences.ai · delivered; no bounce · emergences.ai				
Ephanti	Founding Engineer, Agentic AI	—	Remote US/EU	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers@ephanti.com · delivered; no bounce · ephanti.com				
FanShares	Founding Engineer	\$150–200K + eq	United States	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to leon@fansharesapp.com · delivered; no bounce · fansharesapp.com				
Hermes Web	Founding Engineer	—	Remote worldwide	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Open Core Ventures · Greenhouse confirmation 7/24 (as Open Core Ventures) · job-boards.greenhouse.io				
Hightouch	Role not stated (Greenhouse confirmation)	—	—	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Greenhouse confirmation 7/24 · receipt omitted the role title; deliberately not inferred · hightouch.com				
Hotwash	Founding Engineer	—	Remote US · Boston a plus	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to hiring@hotwash.com · delivered; no bounce · hotwash.com				
JustiGuide	Frontend Engineer	—	—	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers@justiguide.com · delivered; no bounce · justiguide.com				
Kadoa	Senior Software Engineer	—	Fully remote	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to adrian@kadoa.com · delivered; no bounce · kadoa.com				
Kanary	Full Stack Engineer	—	Remote US · Seattle hub	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to steven@kanary.com · delivered; no bounce · kanary.com				
Kyra	Senior/Staff Product Engineer	—	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to n@kyra.health · delivered; no bounce · engineers.kyra.health				

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Lantern DIRECT EMAIL	Junior Software Engineer Direct email to maksym@withlantern.com	— 7/24 · resent 7/26 · counted once · careers.moxxie.vc	Manhattan · 4d/wk	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
LightSight DIRECT EMAIL	Forward Deployed Software Engineer Direct email to contact@lightsight.ai	— delivered; no bounce · lightsight.ai	Remote US · travel	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
Lumen Energy COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Product Engineer Solar/battery climatetech · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com	—	Remote	 Confirmed received	7/24
Mastra COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Product Engineer TypeScript agent framework · Ashby confirmation 7/24 — if fit, recruiter call is next step · jobs.ashbyhq.com	—	Remote worldwide	 Confirmed received	7/24
Mavenly DIRECT EMAIL	Founding Engineer, Full-Stack Direct email to careers@mavenly.ai	\$170–210K + 0.75–1.5% delivered; no bounce · mavenly.ai	Atlanta / Remote US	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
Onboarded COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Product Engineer, full-stack Applied via Lever · Lever confirmation 7/24 · jobs.lever.co	—	Global remote	 Confirmed received	7/24
Ondo Finance COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Full-Stack Software Engineer Greenhouse confirmation received · job-boards.greenhouse.io	Competitive	Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/24
OnePay COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Design Engineer React Native · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com	\$130–160K	Fully remote	 Confirmed received	7/24
Ontix DIRECT EMAIL	Technical Product Manager Direct email to l33t@ontix.io	— delivered; no bounce · ontix.io	Remote US	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
OpenEd COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Product Engineer ⚠ Backers still unverified — sanity-check before investing more · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/24
Pax Historia DIRECT EMAIL	Founding Engineer (Full Stack Web) Direct email to careers@paxhistoria.co	\$150–215K + 0.25–1% delivered; no bounce · ycombinator.com	San Francisco · in-person	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
Puma Browser DIRECT EMAIL	AI/ML Engineer Direct email to careers+ai@pumabrowser.com	— delivered; no bounce · puma.tech	Remote-first	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
Resend COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Product Engineer Ashby confirmation 7/24 — "a real human will review" · resend.com	\$151–170K	Fully remote	 Confirmed received	7/24
Riot IQ DIRECT EMAIL	AI-native Software Engineer Direct email to robertneir@riotiq.com	— delivered; no bounce · riotiq.com	Seattle / Remote US	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
SalvoHealth COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Software Engineer Lever confirmation received · jobs.lever.co	\$100–160K	NYC / Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/24
SecureFlow DIRECT EMAIL	Junior Software Engineer Direct email to Josepbbob@proton.me	\$80–110K + 0.1–0.3% delivered; no bounce · secureflow.tech	Remote global	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
Span COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Product Engineer Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com	\$100–200K + eq	Fully remote	 Confirmed received	7/24
Teckfinitly DIRECT EMAIL	AI / Agent Engineer Direct email to recruitment@teckfinitly.com	— delivered; no bounce · teckfinitly.com	Remote	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
TrueBuilt NOT RECORDED	Founding Engineer Pre-construction platform · no confirmation email yet · job-boards.greenhouse.io	—	Remote-first	 Submitted, no reply	7/24

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Vertex	AI Product Engineer	\$101–136K	Remote US	☑️ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Was in backlog — applied via Workday · mention HN to Paul Chung if contacted · Workday confirmation 7/24 · vertexinc.wd1.myworkdayjobs.com					
Wheelhouse	Full Stack Engineer	—	Remote-first	☑️ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM React/Next/TS + dataviz · Greenhouse confirmation 7/24 · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
Wildflower Health	Junior Software Engineer	—	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to chris.reath@wildflowerhealth.com · delivered; exact role now archived · wildflowerhealth.com					
Yuzu	Product Engineer	\$140–265K + eq	NYC · 5d/wk	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to kev@yuzu.health; OOO redirected to ryan@yuzu.health · counted once · yuzu.health					

JULY 23, 2026 — 7 VERIFIED

AgentPress	Full-Stack AI Engineer	—	Remote US/Canada	☑️ Confirmed received	7/23
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to apply@agent.press · automated receipt used legacy Emerge Haus branding · agent.press					
Airtable	Design Technologist	\$224–317.2K	NYC / SF hybrid 2–3d/wk	☑️ Confirmed received	7/23
NOT RECORDED Restored 7/24 audit — confirmation from jobs@airtable.com 7/23 · AI-assisted workflow answers · Worldbook as latest AI experiment · airtable.com					
Aqua Voice	Design Engineer	\$130–210K + eq/bonus	NYC / SF on-site	☑️ Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Restored 7/24 audit — Ashby confirmation 7/23 (received twice) · six solo products + ThreadKeep pitch · aquavoice.com					
Ashby	Junior Design Engineer, Americas	\$122–220K + eq	Remote US	☑️ Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Was in backlog — applied 7/23 · Ashby confirmation received (found in Gmail) · ashbyhq.com					
Gumloop	Design Engineer	—	NYC / SF / Vancouver on-site	☑️ Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Restored 7/24 audit — Ashby confirmation 7/23 · agent-legibility pitch · confirmed NYC office availability · gumloop.com					
Pace	Design Engineer (first design hire)	Competitive + early eq	NYC on-site	☑️ Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Restored 7/24 audit — Ashby confirmation 7/23 · first Design Engineer · WPCNA maps 1:1 · \$46M Series B insurance AI · jobs.ashbyhq.com					
Rillet	Design Engineer	\$150–240K	NYC / SF hybrid	🚫 Rejected	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby rejection 7/27 — “moving forward with other candidates,” invited to reapply as new roles open · Ashby confirmation 7/23 · full arc concept → shipped · AI-native design-to-code · rillet.com					

JULY 22, 2026 — 18 VERIFIED

Credal.ai	Founding Design Engineer	\$170–230K + eq	Brooklyn, on-site	☑️ Confirmed received	7/22
DIRECT EMAIL Follow-up emailed to Ravin (CEO) · credal.ai					
Dimely	Founding Engineer, Full Stack	\$100–140K + 1–3%	Remote / Hybrid SF	☑️ Confirmed received	7/22
YC BOARD Dover confirmation — the “lost form” actually went through · YC S24, 4th hire · usedimely.com					
Fifth Door	Front End Engineer — games + AI	— + eq	Remote US 🐻	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED Daniel · Ad Arma maps 1:1 — strongest-fit pitch of the run · fifthdoor.com					
Finta	Founding Designer (employee #3)	\$140–220K + 1–5%	SF / Remote 🐻	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED Andy · designs-in-code pitch · portfolio-review interview · finta.com					

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Git AI NOT RECORDED	Founding Engineer Pitch sent direct to founder (Aidan) · alternate Gmail draft is dead — delete · usegitai.com	\$190–220K + eq	NYC in-person	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Hera NOT RECORDED	Founding Product Designer Peter (CEO) · "slope not intercept" · hera.video	€80–130K + eq	Berlin pref / NY remote	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Humwork NOT RECORDED	Founding Engineer Email to founders@ (their preferred channel) · they reply within 48h — watch inbox · humwork.ai	\$120–150K + 2.5–10%	SF in-person	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Infisical NOT RECORDED	Developer Advocate Tony · teaching/translation pitch · 7/24: they viewed Mike's LinkedIn — worth a look at their other openings · infisical.com	\$120–190K	Remote US/CA	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Infisical NOT RECORDED	Design Engineer, Brand Double-apply flagged as intentional · infisical.com	\$100–180K	Remote US/CA	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Nixo NOT RECORDED	Founding Member of Technical Staff Priya · WPCNA deployment-mess story · ycombinator.com	\$150–250K + eq	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Novig NOT RECORDED	AI Automation Engineer Gambling domain — ignore any reply · novig.com	\$200–230K	NYC	📧 Confirmed received	7/22
Onlook NOT RECORDED	Founding Engineer — "Cursor for Designers" Daniel · "the user Onlook exists for" pitch · onlook.com	\$130–200K + eq	Remote US 🐶	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Pillar NOT RECORDED	Founding Designer Creator-economy suite · "I was your user for 20 years" · ycombinator.com	—	Remote US 🐶	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
ProhostAI NOT RECORDED	Founding Engineer, Full Stack Bill · Airbnb/Dropbox founders · honest-gap pitch · prohost.ai	\$100–180K + eq	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Rivet WEB FORM	Full Stack Engineer (early team) Google Form recorded · AI direct-to-fan platform for artists · favorite band: Tool · rivet.app	Not posted — quoted \$110–140K	Remote US 🐶	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Scott AI YC BOARD	Design Engineer YC F25 · planning layer for coding-agent teams · Metro-North commutable · tryscott.ai	\$140–250K + 0.5–1.5%	NYC / SF office	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
The Company Company YC BOARD	Founding Design Engineer Julius · 1-person YC P26 · watch WaaS inbox · workatastartup.com	\$130–200K + eq	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/22
Tsenta COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Founding Engineer Applied via Ashby · live conversation — the only human contact so far · tsenta.com	—	Remote US	🟢 <u>A human engaged</u>	7/22
JULY 21, 2026 — 5 VERIFIED					
Anthropic COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Design Engineer, Web Greenhouse confirmation · timeline is Feb 2026 — never say two years · anthropic.com	\$260–305K	Remote, 25% office	📧 Confirmed received	7/21
GitHub COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Design Engineer III (Req 5478) iCIMS rejection 7/23 — reviewed by a Talent Partner, "moving forward with other candidates" · first decision of the campaign · github.com	\$153.9–285.9K	Remote	🚫 Rejected	7/21
Luma AI NOT RECORDED	Forward Deployed Creative [US] Gem confirmation received · lumalabs.ai	\$150–200K	NY / LA / PA office	📧 Confirmed received	7/21

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
OpenAI NOT RECORDED	Model Designer, Core Models Their system parsed first name as "White" (autofill glitch) — correct casually if contacted · openai.com	\$266–295K + eq	SF hybrid 3d/wk	 Confirmed received	7/21
Runway COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Design Engineer, Runway Labs Ashby confirmation · earlier 7/7 email to recruiting@ = same application · runwayml.com	\$250–310K	Remote	 Confirmed received	7/21
JULY 14, 2026 — 1 VERIFIED					
Hugging Face NOT RECORDED	Wild Card application The one that started the campaign · Workable confirmation · fresh anchor application queued · huggingface.co	—	Remote	 Confirmed received	7/14
JULY 7, 2026 — 6 VERIFIED					
Arize NOT RECORDED	Open Source Design Engineer No reply · arize.com	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
Collier.Simon NOT RECORDED	Creative Technologist One thread (original + 2 corrections) · no reply · colliersimon.com	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
Felt NOT RECORDED	Spatial tools / creative technologist "Application received" auto-ack · felt.com	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/7
Lightning Labs NOT RECORDED	AI Product Engineer No reply · lightning.engineering	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
Scenario NOT RECORDED	Creative Technologist Canned ack only (29s after send) · scenario.com	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
USB Club / garden3d NOT RECORDED	Part-time Design Engineer Sent to Hugh · no reply · garden3d.net	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7

Appendix — plain-language glossary

Extracted from the live tracker so the paper and the website always say the same thing.

HOW AN APPLICATION TRAVELS

ATS *also: applicant tracking system, applicant tracking systems*

The software a company uses to collect and sort applications. Ashby, Greenhouse, Lever, Workday and iCIMS are the ones that turn up most often on this page.

ATS confirmation *also: automated confirmation, confirmation email, application confirmation, application receipt*

The automatic email their system sends the moment an application lands. It proves the file arrived; it does not mean a person has opened it.

portal *also: portals, candidate portal, application portal*

A company's own web page where you type in your history and upload a résumé instead of emailing anyone. Most of them make you retype everything that is already on the résumé you just attached.

req *also: reqs, requisition, requisitions, job requisition*

The internal ticket saying a company has the budget to pay one more person, usually with a number attached. No req, no job — even if the posting is still up.

autoresponder *also: auto-reply, autoreply, auto-ack, canned ack, automated receipt, automatic reply*

A pre-written reply that fires the second your message arrives, sometimes within seconds. It tells you the machine is working, and nothing about your chances.

no-reply *also: noreply, no-reply address, do-not-reply, donotreply*

An address that can send mail but cannot receive it, so answering it goes nowhere. To reach an actual person you have to find their real address yourself.

bounced *also: bounce, bounces, bounced back, hard bounce*

The message never reached anyone — the address was wrong or dead and the mail system sent it back. Notes here that say “no bounce” mean the opposite: it arrived.

cold email *also: cold emails, cold outreach, cold emailed, cold-emailed*

Writing straight to someone at a company that never posted the job you want. It is not rude, and at small companies it is often how hiring actually starts.

referral *also: referrals, referred, internal referral*

Someone inside the company passes your name along, which lifts you out of the pile and in front of a human. It is the biggest single advantage in hiring, and the main reason two people with the same experience get very different results.

WHO YOU ARE TALKING TO

recruiter *also: recruiters, in-house recruiter*

The person whose job is to find candidates and move them through the steps. They are not the one who decides, and they are usually juggling dozens of openings at once.

Talent Partner *also: talent partners, talent acquisition partner, talent acquisition*

A recruiter with a warmer job title. Same work: finding people, booking calls, and sending the yes or the no.

agency *also: agencies, recruiting agency, staffing agency, agency recruiter, external recruiter*

An outside firm that finds candidates for other companies and is paid only when someone is hired. They can be genuinely helpful, but the company is the one paying them, not you.

hiring manager *also: hiring managers*

The person you would actually work for, and the one who decides. Everyone before them is a filter.

hotlist *also: hot list, talent pool, talent community*

A list of people a company says it will remember when something opens up. Saying it costs them nothing, and almost nobody is ever contacted from one.

STAGES

Submitted *also: submitted, no reply*

Sent, and nothing has come back — no receipt, no rejection, not a word. This is where most rows on this page sit.

Submitted ✓ *also: confirmed received*

Their system sent back a receipt, so the application is known to have arrived. The mark shows where a row stands today, so two applications that later turned into a rejection or a conversation no longer carry it.

screen *also: phone screen, recruiter screen, screening call, initial screen*

A short first call, usually twenty or thirty minutes with a recruiter, to check the basics. It is a gate, not really an interview.

take-home *also: take home, take-home assignment, take-home project, take home test*

A piece of real work you do alone, on your own time, unpaid, and send back. Reasonable ones take an evening; unreasonable ones eat a weekend.

loop *also: interview loop, onsite loop, final loop, onsite interviews*

The final round: several interviews back to back, often in one day, with different people. Afterwards they compare notes and decide together.

Conversation *also: live conversation, live conversations, conversations*

A real person wrote back and a genuine back-and-forth started. It is the rarest status on this page.

Rejected *also: rejection, rejections, declined, passed on*

They said no. Sometimes it arrives as a form letter, occasionally as a real note from a real person.

in pipeline *also: pipeline, in the pipeline*

Applications still alive in some form — sent, confirmed, or being talked about — with no final answer yet. Silence keeps a row here until it is plainly dead.

backlog *also: in backlog, moved from backlog*

Jobs worth applying to that have not gone out yet. Keeping them separate is what stops good intentions from being counted as work done.

MONEY AND OWNERSHIP

base *also: base salary, base pay*

The cash salary, before anything else is added on. It is the only part you can actually count on.

equity *also: eq, equity grant, ownership stake*

A slice of ownership in the company, handed over instead of some of the cash. It is worth nothing unless the company is later sold or goes public.

options *also: stock options, share options, option grant*

The right to buy company shares later at a price fixed today. If the company grows you buy cheap; if it does not, you simply never buy.

vesting *also: vest, vests, vested, vesting schedule*

You earn your equity gradually, month by month, rather than receiving it on day one. Leave early and you keep only the part you have earned so far.

cliff *also: one-year cliff, 1-year cliff, vesting cliff*

A waiting period, usually a full year, before any equity is yours at all. Leave a day before it and you walk away with none of it.

OTE *also: on-target earnings, on target earnings*

Salary plus the bonus you would earn if you hit every target. Read it as the best case, not as the offer.

comp *also: compensation, total comp, comp package, total compensation*

Everything you are paid — salary, bonus, equity and benefits — added into one number. Companies quote the big total; the cash part is the part that pays rent.

WHERE WORK HAPPENS

Remote *also: remote US, fully remote, remote-first, remote global, remote worldwide, work from home*

You work from where you live. Read the fine print — remote usually still means a particular country, and often specific hours overlapping someone else's day.

Hybrid *also: hybrid schedule, part remote*

Some days in the office, the rest at home, with the split set by the company rather than by you. Listings here spell it out, like three days a week.

On-site *also: onsite, in-person, in person, in the office*

You are expected in the building, most days or every day. For these jobs that usually means living near New York or San Francisco.

ROLE TITLES

Design Engineer *also: design engineers, design technologist, creative technologist*

Someone who designs how a thing looks and behaves, then writes the code that makes it real. Some companies call the same job design technologist or creative technologist.

Founding Engineer *also: founding engineers, founding design engineer, founding designer, founding member of technical staff, member of technical staff*

One of the first few people building the product, before there are teams, managers or process. More ownership and more equity, with no guarantee the company lasts.

Product Engineer *also: product engineers*

An engineer trusted to decide what to build, not only how to build it, working close to the people who use it. The opposite of being handed a finished spec.

Full-Stack *also: full stack, fullstack, full-stack engineer, full stack engineer, full-stack developer*

Able to work on the part people see and the machinery behind it. At a small company it usually just means everything.

STARTUP VOCABULARY

YC *also: Y Combinator, YCombinator*

Y Combinator, the best known startup program: it gives brand-new companies a little money and three months of coaching in exchange for a piece of them. Tags like S24 or F25 say which batch a company came through.

WaaS *also: Work at a Startup*

Work at a Startup, Y Combinator's own job board for the companies it has funded. A few of the applications here went out through it.

accelerator *also: accelerators, startup accelerator, incubator*

A short program that funds a group of new companies, coaches them, and ends with them pitching investors. Y Combinator is the famous one.

Ashby

One of the systems companies use to take in applications, common at startups. Its automatic receipt is what puts the check mark on many rows here.

Greenhouse

Another widely used application system, more common at bigger companies. Its receipt sometimes leaves the job title out, which is why a couple of rows here say the role was not stated.

iCIMS

An older application system, used mostly by large established employers. It produced the first rejection of this campaign.

Polymer

A smaller, newer application system used by one company on this list. Same purpose as the rest: take applications in and sort them.

WHAT THE POLITE PHRASES ACTUALLY MEAN

moving forward with other candidates *also: move forward with other candidates, moving forward with others, decided to move forward with other candidates, pursuing other candidates*

This is a no. It is the standard phrasing for a rejection, and it does not mean a decision is still open.

not a great fit *also: not a fit, not a good fit, not the right fit, not quite the right fit, not a fit for the current role*

Also a no, usually a kind one. It rarely means anything specific about you, and asking what was missing almost never gets an answer.

keep you on our hotlist *also: keeping him on their hotlist, keeping you on our hotlist, on our hotlist, keep you on file, keep your resume on file, keep your résumé on file*

A gentle way to end things without saying never. It costs nothing to say and rarely leads anywhere, so treat it as a no with the door left ajar.

we'll be in touch *also: we'll be in touch, we will be in touch, we'll be in touch soon, be in touch*

On its own, this means nothing. With a date or a named next step attached it is real; without one, expect silence.

reach out *also: reach back out, reaching out, we'll reach out, we'll reach out*

Office language for “get in touch”. When they say they will reach out, no promise has been made; when you do it yourself, it is the part of a job hunt that actually works.

circle back *also: circling back, circle back with you, come back to you*

To return to something later. In hiring it nearly always means no decision is being made today, and often none is ever made.